



PORTUGAL

Capital city: Lisbon

Area: 35,672 sq miles
(92,391 sq km)

Population: 10,100,000

Official language:
PortugueseMajor religions: Christian
98%, other 2%Government: Multiparty
democracy

Currency: Euro

Adult literacy rate: 93%

Life expectancy: 76 years

People per doctor: 312

Televisions: 452 per
1,000 people

PORTUGAL

A NATION OF GREAT SEAFARERS, Portuguese explorers sailed the world in the 15th and 16th centuries. They claimed territories as far apart as Africa and Asia, and they also colonized Brazil. From 1932–1968 Portugal was ruled by the dictator António Salazar, but after a military coup in 1974, the armed forces finally withdrew from politics. In 1986 Portugal joined the European Community, but it remains one of the poorest countries in western Europe. Tourism, particularly in the Algarve, is important to the economy.

RURAL LIFE

Traditional farming methods, unchanged for centuries, are still used in many parts of Portugal. In some villages, oxen wearing carved wooden yokes still pull the plows. One of the country's main crops is corn, which was brought back from the Americas by Christopher Columbus in the 15th century. Other crops include olives and figs. Wine, cork, and tomatoes are exported abroad and fishing remains important along the Atlantic coast.



LISBON

The capital of Portugal, Lisbon, lies at the mouth of the Tagus River. In the 15th century, Lisbon was a major port and world center for the spice and gold trade. The Tower of Belem, shown here, sits on the site where the explorer Vasco da Gama set sail. Today, many old palaces and mansions have been converted into elegant restaurants and bars, shops, and art galleries.



CRAFTS

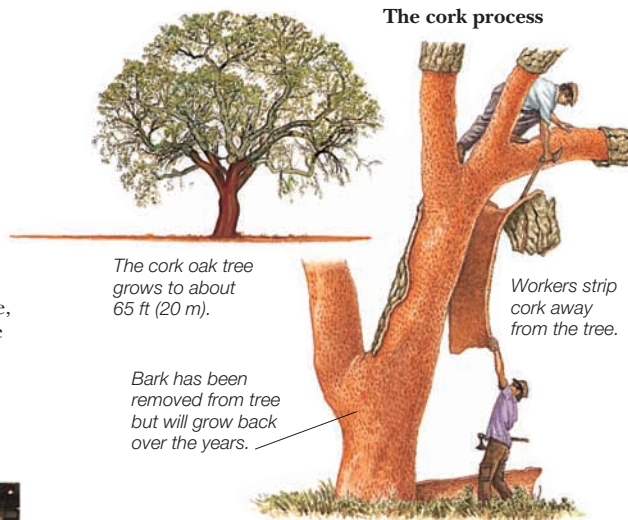
Traditional Portuguese handicrafts include ceramic tiles, called *azulejos*, which are often used to decorate buildings. Street markets also display other local specialties, such as brightly colored pottery, painted furniture, glassware, and porcelain. Delicate silver filigree jewelry and richly embroidered cloth from the island of Madeira are exported all over the world.



Students celebrate graduation



The cork process



THE CORK INDUSTRY

Almost 10 percent of Portugal is covered with cork oak trees, the bark of which is used to make cork products. The thick, spongy bark is stripped off and left to dry. It is then steamed or boiled to soften it and pressed into sheets ready for use. Portugal is the world's leading exporter of cork for products such as bottle stoppers, tiles, and the insides of badminton birdies. By law, the bark is only removed every nine years so the trees can recover. Trees can provide cork for more than 100 years.



THE PORTUGUESE

Most Portuguese people are Roman Catholics. Family life is very important and girls often live at home until they marry, although more are now continuing their education and taking up careers. The *Queima das Fitas*, a festival held each May, celebrates university graduation. In recent years, as many as 3 million Portuguese have gone abroad in search of work. Some leave families behind, but send money home to support them.

Find out more

EUROPEAN UNION: 81, 273
OLIVE GROWING: 130
POLITICAL SYSTEMS: 270–271
ROMAN CATHOLICS: 274